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Every Step You Take, I will be watching you

GLOBAL POSITIONING IS a great technology. But like all great technologies, this one too could be a Frankenstein's monster. Michael Rosenwald on Popular Science explains how in this perceptive, well-researched piece.



They fell for each other in grade school, in the sweetest of ways. In fifth-grade music class, she played saxophone; he played the snare drum. In high school biology, she held the frog while he wielded the scalpel. It was the sort of love story immortalized endlessly in romance novels and Top 40 long-distance dedications. "I thought when I married him it really would be 'till death do us part'," she says now, still surprised that the marriage ended after 19 years. Ultimately, the romance had sputtered to a close, as so many love stories do. Unlike most love stories,

though, this ending involved satellites.

One day, six months after she filed for divorce, the woman's husband, Robert Sullivan, was searching the Internet when he came across an ad for the TravelEyes Tracking Unit, a GPS device that, when installed in a vehicle and later removed and connected to a computer, shows a digital map of every stop and turn the car has made, and even its speed. A person employing such a device knows as much about the car's recent whereabouts as he would if he'd been riding in it himself. Sullivan immediately placed an order; it seems he felt he could put such a contraption to good use.

This all unfolded five years ago in a small Colorado city near Boulder. He was a maintenance worker at a factory. She worked with handicapped students at the nearby university. They were, by her description, just simple people raising two sons and paying their bills, living the sort of anonymous existence politicians exalt when making pronouncements about "the American people." But among law-enforcement officials and victims' advocates, their story, and particularly Robert Sullivan's role, has become notorious. GPS-the Global Positioning System, which pinpoints a user's location by triangulating radio signals emitted by an array of satellites-was making its journey from military use to civilian ubiquity. At the time, GPS devices were being marketed to track delivery trucks and rental cars; early adopters were carrying them along on wilderness hikes to serve as high-tech breadcrumbs. In a stroke of inspiration, Sullivan co-opted the technology for his own purposes, and in so doing helped to steer stalking into the 21st century.

It was a remarkably undemanding mission. The Internet had made it possible to purchase novel gadgets of virtually any sort, regardless of where one lived. Sullivan didn't even install the device himself-he had his kids do the job. He called his wife over to the house, where they talked about the divorce proceedings. Meanwhile their teenage boys, whom Sullivan had convinced were being abandoned by their mother, went outside to "change the oil" in her car. Instead they installed the TravelEyes unit.

Feel like reading the entire piece? Visit snipurl.com/gpsterror

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Another Chapter In The Google-Microsoft War



JOHN C DVORAK is one of the most respected columnists in technology media. Here's why...

There's been a lot of gossip about the upcoming Google browser and its possible impact on Microsoft. It's hard to predict what will happen, but it won't surprise me if an all-out war between Google and Microsoft ensues. We are about to witness a repeat of the Netscape browser war-this time with a

different strategy.

It's unlikely that Google will ever sell its browser. The company has developed a strategy to make money on advertising. The strategy works, and it gives Google a clear edge over Microsoft; Google can give away everything.

Besides its premier search engine, Google recently started Gmail, which competes head-on with Hotmail and has even forced Hotmail to add more free storage for its users. Google News competes with MSN in a subtle but important way too, by providing a useful home page of news. The browser will draw a new battle line. I suspect that Google may well be on its way toward exercising the strategy that Netscape threatened years ago, when its executives asserted that they could take over the desktop. Google could be trying to make the browser its nexus in a desktop strategy to eliminate the need for Microsoft Windows.

I don't really think that Windows and Microsoft can be marginalized by a browser-centric environment that relies more and more on the Internet, remote-application servers, and no real operating environment. I think there is a place for such a system, but I'm not expecting to see anyone running Microsoft PowerPoint slides from the Internet rather than from local storage anytime soon. Furthermore, the current glut of inexpensive hard drives with capacities between 100GB and 250GB makes the current architectural model for the PC too practical to go away anytime in the near future. Still, not everybody needs a high-performance Windows machine with a 250GB hard drive. Microsoft could easily lose part of the market to any number of configurations. You can be sure that the company will see the Google browser as its biggest threat and find ways to thwart Google.

According to some valley gossip, Google is already raiding Microsoft for browser developers right out of the Microsoft Internet Explorer staff.

It's possible that the entire Google browser initiative is nothing more than a retribution maneuver, because Microsoft has recently made a lot of noise about the super search engine that it intends to roll out-a Google killer. When fully realized, this engine is supposed to be able to do natural-language queries, which have always been laughable.

Visit snipurl.com/aczc to read Dvorak's complete column